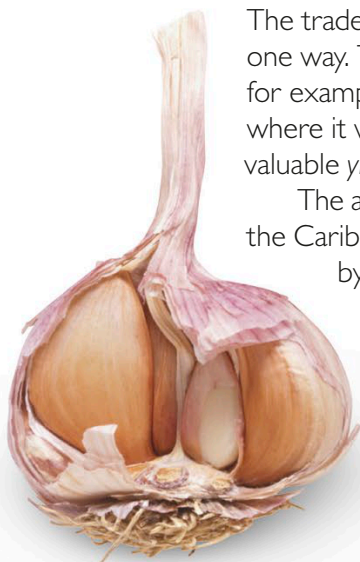




Garlic is native to Asia but was readily adopted for its medicinal and culinary qualities in the West.

The trade in herbs was not entirely one way. The European herb sage, for example, came into use in China, where it was considered to be a valuable *yin* tonic.

The arrival of Columbus' ships in the Caribbean in 1492 was followed by the rapid conquest and colonization of central and south America by the Spanish and Portuguese. Along with their booty of plundered gold, the conquistadores returned to the Old World with previously unheard-of medicinal plants. Many of these herbs from the Americas had highly potent medicinal actions, and they

soon became available in the apothecaries of the major European cities. Plants such as *lignum vitae* (*Guaiacum officinale*, p. 218) and *cinchona* (*Cinchona* spp., p. 80) with strong medicinal actions were used with greater and lesser degrees of success as treatments for fever, malaria, syphilis, smallpox, and other serious illnesses.

For most rural communities, however, the only foreign plants that were used medicinally were those that could also be grown locally as foods. Garlic offers one of the earliest and clearest examples. Originating in central Asia, over time it was cultivated farther and farther west and was grown in Egypt around 4500 BCE. In Homer's 8th-century BCE epic poem *The Odyssey*, the hero is saved from being changed into a pig thanks to garlic. The herb was introduced into Britain after the Roman conquest in the 1st century CE, and by the time it reached the island its remarkable medicinal powers were well understood. In later centuries, potatoes (*Solanum tuberosum*, p. 271) and corn (*Zea mays*, p. 154), both native to South America, would become common foods. These plants have clear medicinal as well as nutritional benefits. Potato juice is a valuable remedy for the treatment of arthritis, while cornsilk makes an effective decoction for urinary problems such as cystitis.

Health & Hygiene 1400–1700

Between the 12th and 18th centuries, the influx of exotic medicinal plants added to an already large number of useful European herbs. Conceivably, an overall improvement of health in Europe might have resulted. After all, not only were new medicinal plants available, but Europeans had the opportunity to observe the different medical practices of people in South America, China, Japan, and especially in India, where trade was well established. But, in fact, the reverse was the case. People living in Europe during this period probably

experienced some of the most unhealthy conditions the world has ever seen. In contrast, Native Americans before the arrival of Columbus lived longer, healthier lives than their counterparts in Europe. This fact is unsurprising given the cities of medieval Europe, with their open sewers, overcrowding, and ignorance of simple hygiene.

Conditions such as these laid fertile ground for the spread of plague-infested rats from the ports of the Mediterranean throughout Western Europe. From the mid-14th century onward, plague killed millions, in some cases close to 50 percent of the population. No medical treatment—herbal or mineral—was able to alter its fatal course. Epidemics continued to decimate the cities of Europe and Asia well into the 18th century. An outbreak in India in 1994 reawakened the terror inspired simply at the mention of the word “plague.”

Syphilis was another disease spread by seafarers. It was reputedly brought back from the Caribbean to Naples by Columbus' crew in the 1490s, spreading quickly throughout Europe and to the rest of the world, reaching China in 1550.

European doctors had little success in combating diseases as devastating as plague. The medicine they practiced was based on the blind acceptance of Galen's humoral principles. Perhaps if, as in Chinese and Indian medicine, European medicine had continued to evolve, revising ancient medical texts and reinterpreting them in the light of new discoveries, it would have had greater success. As it was, European physicians were at least as likely to kill their patients

with bloodletting and toxic minerals in misbegotten attempts to balance the humors as they were to cure.

Indeed, the increasingly fashionable use of mineral cures such as mercury led to the growth of chemical formulations, culminating in scientific medicine's ultimate break away from herbal practices.

The Influence of Paracelsus

One of the key European figures of the 16th century was Paracelsus (1493–1541), a larger-than-life character who rejected the tired repetition of Galen's theories in favor of detailed observation in medicine. “I have not borrowed from Hippocrates, Galen, or anyone else,” he wrote, “having acquired my knowledge from the best teacher, that is, by



17th-century doctor wearing a costume designed to protect against contamination by the plague.